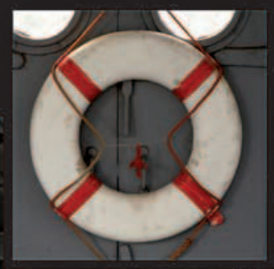
BELOW DECKS

THE ACCOMMODATIONS FOR *Mikasa*'s 840 officers and men was quite austere. Even the admiral's living space was simple, if comfortable. The other ranks slept in hammocks among the guns, as in Nelson's day. The ship could carry 2,000 tons of coal to fuel the triple expansion steam engines, which gave a maximum speed of 18 knots. Working conditions in the depths of the ship, amid the heat and noise of the engine rooms, were harsh. In battle men were acutely aware that a ship of this kind could be an iron coffin, sinking in minutes if badly holed. The upper deck where Admiral Togo stood in battle was protected only by sandbags from enemy fire. The ship was equipped with the newly invented wireless (radio) giving the Japanese fleet an advantage over the Russians in communications.

» Life ring
Mikasa carried several cork life rings in case of man overboard, as well as 14 lifeboats and launches of various sizes.





» 3-in gun casemate
Eight 3-in Quick Firing (QF) guns are mounted along the sides of the ship in armored casemates. Too light to penetrate the armor of opposing battleships, the guns provided a defense against fast torpedo boats and destroyers.

» Ship's wheel
The polished wood and brass wheel from *Mikasa*'s pilothouse. A second wheel was located in an armored conning tower for the helmsman to use during battle.



» Pilothouse
The ship was steered from the pilothouse using the wheel and engine order telegraphs. A compass is mounted inside a large brass binnacle case.





« » Entrance to 3-in casemate
After the battle of Tsushima, the Russian Rear Admiral Nikolai Nebogatov entered the *Mikasa* through this door in the armored casemate to present his sword and the surrender of his five remaining ships to Admiral Togo.

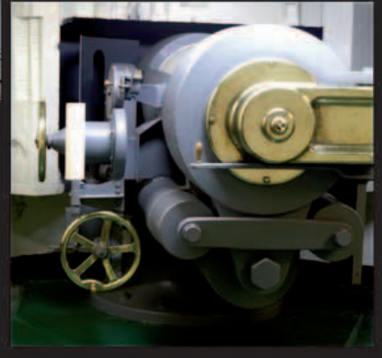


» Morse key
Messages were tapped in using this Morse key and transmitted using *Mikasa*'s new wireless telegraphy equipment—a novel technology at the time *Mikasa* was launched in 1900.





» 6-in broadside gun
Underneath each of the 3-in gun casemates, fixed in place behind 6-in (15-cm) of steel plating, was a line of three 6-in Quick Firing (QF) guns. Several more were fitted on the corners of the gun decks, bringing the total number to 14.



» 6-in Quick Firing gun breech
The Quick Firing (QF) guns on *Mikasa* used a breech-loading mechanism and single-piece ammunition containing both the shell and propellant to enable more rapid loading.